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FAST FACTS

Tuition costs of colleges and universities

Question:

What are the trends in the cost of college education?

Response:

The total cost of attending a postsecondary institution includes the sum of published tuition and required fees;[1,2] books and supplies; and the average cost for room, board, and other expenses for each institution. In academic year 2022–23, the average total cost of attendance[3] for first-time, full-time degree/certificate-seeking undergraduate students differed by control of institution (public, private nonprofit, or private for-profit) and level of institution (4-year or 2-year). In addition, the average total cost of attendance varied by student living arrangement. A student could live on campus; off campus with family; or off campus but not with family. For example, in 2022–23, the average total cost of attendance for first-time, full-time undergraduate students living on campus at 4-year degree-granting institutions was higher at private nonprofit institutions ($58,600) than at private for-profit institutions ($33,600) and public institutions ($27,100).[4]

Figure 2. Average tuition and fees of degree-granting institutions for first-time, full-time degree/certificate-seeking undergraduate students, by level and control of institution: Academic years 2012–13 through 2022–23

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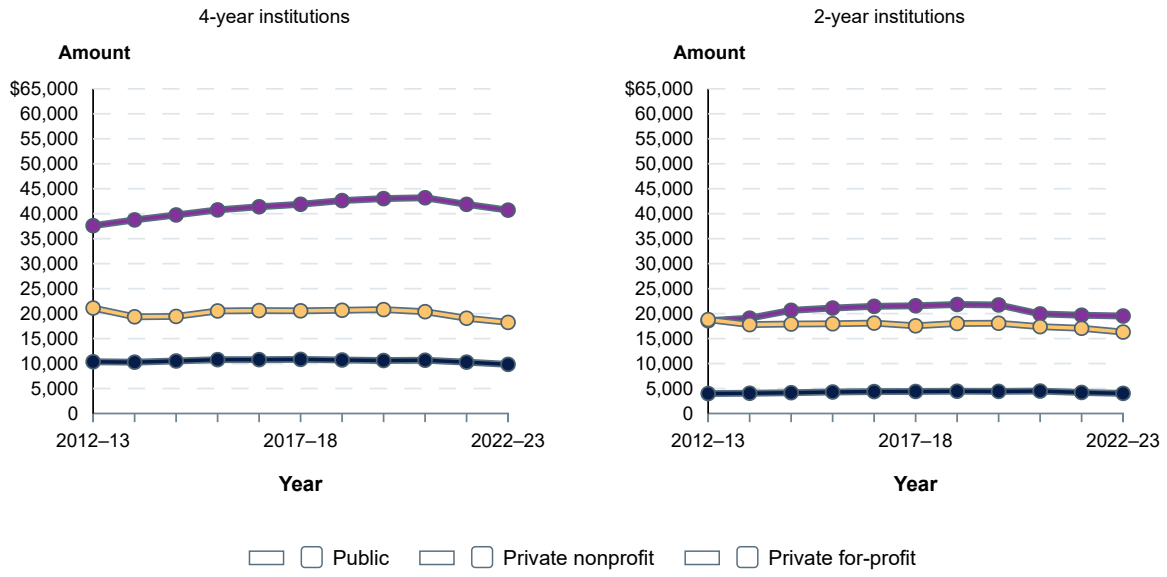
[In constant 2022–23 dollars]



NOTE: Data are for the 50 states and the District of Columbia. Tuition and fees at public institutions are the lower of either in-district or in-state tuition and fees. Excludes students who previously attended another postsecondary institution or who began their studies on a part-time basis. Data are for degree-granting institutions, which grant associate's or higher degrees and participate in Title IV federal financial aid programs, and U.S. service academies. Data are weighted by the number of first-time, full-time degree/certificate-seeking undergraduate students at the institution who were awarded Title IV aid. Title IV aid includes grant aid, work-study aid, and loan aid. Constant dollars are based on the Consumer Price Index, prepared by the Bureau of Labor Statistics, U.S. Department of Labor, adjusted to an academic-year basis. Figures are plotted based on unrounded data.

SOURCE: U.S. Department of Education, National Center for Education Statistics, Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS), Student Financial Aid component and Institutional Characteristics component, Spring 2011 (final data), Winter 2022–23 (provisional data), Fall 2012 (final data) through Fall 2022 (provisional data). See *Digest of Education Statistics 2016*, table 330.40, *Digest of Education Statistics 2017*, table 330.40, *Digest of Education Statistics 2020*, table 330.40, *Digest of Education Statistics 2022*, table 330.40, and *Digest of Education Statistics 2023*, table 330.40.

At all types of degree-granting institutions, average tuition and fees[5] for first-time, full-time degree/certificate-seeking students increased by less than the rate of inflation from 2021–22 to 2022–23. Therefore, in constant dollars,[6] average tuition and fees were lower in 2022–23 than they were the year before. However, longer-term trends from 2012–13 to 2022–23 varied by level and control of institution.

At 4-year institutions, average tuition and fees in 2022–23 were

- $9,800 for public institutions, which was 5 percent lower than $10,400 in 2012–13;
- $18,200 for private for-profit institutions, which was 14 percent lower than $21,100 in 2012–13; and
- $40,700 for private nonprofit institutions, which was 8 percent higher than $37,600 in 2012–13.

Despite recent annual declines, private nonprofit institutions experienced an increase in average tuition and fees between 2012–13 and 2022–23. In contrast, at public and private for-profit 4-year institutions, average tuition and fees during this period were at their lowest point in 2022–23.

At 2-year degree-granting institutions, average tuition and fees in 2022–23 were

- $4,000 for public institutions, which was 1 percent higher than in 2012–13 (also rounded to $4,000);
- $16,300 for private for-profit institutions, which was 13 percent lower than $18,800 in 2012–13; and
- $19,500 for private nonprofit institutions, which was 5 percent higher than $18,600 in 2012–13.

Average tuition and fees at private for-profit 2-year institutions were highest in 2012–13, followed by a decline over the period. In contrast, average tuition and fees at public and private nonprofit 2-year institutions over this period were both lowest in 2012–13 and then peaked in 2020–21 ($4,500) and 2018–19 ($21,800), respectively.

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[1] For general technical notes related to data analysis, data interpretation, rounding, and other considerations, please refer to the Reader's Guide.

[2] For public institutions, this is the lower of in-district or in-state published tuition and required fees.

[3] The total cost of attending a postsecondary institution includes tuition and required fees; books and supplies; and the average cost for room, board, and other expenses. Tuition and fees at public institutions are the lower of either in-district or in-state tuition and fees.

[4] Data in this Fast Fact represent the 50 states and the District of Columbia.

[5] Average tuition and fees presented in this Fast Fact are based on a different population than the one used in Loans for Undergraduate Students. Tuition and fees in this Fast Fact are based on reporting for first-time, full-time degree/certificate-seeking students, rather than all full-time students.

[6] All dollar amounts in this Fast Fact are expressed in constant 2022–23 dollars. Constant dollars are based on the Consumer Price Index, prepared by the Bureau of Labor Statistics, U.S. Department of Labor, adjusted to an academic-year basis.

SOURCE: National Center for Education Statistics. (2024). Price of Attending an Undergraduate Institution. *Condition of Education.* U.S. Department of Education, Institute of Education Sciences. Retrieved May 30, 2024, from https://nces.ed.gov/programs/coe/indicator/cua.

Numbers in figure titles reflect original numeration from source Condition of Education indicators.

Related Tables and Figures: **(Listed by Release Date)**

- 2024, Digest of Education Statistics 2023, Table 330.10. Average undergraduate tuition, fees, room, and board rates charged for full-time students in degree-granting postsecondary institutions, by level and control of institution: Selected academic years, 1963–64 through 2022–23
- 2024, Digest of Education Statistics 2023, Table 330.20. Average undergraduate tuition, fees, room, and board charges for full-time students in degree-granting postsecondary institutions, by control and level of institution and state: Academic years 2021-22 and 2022-23
- 2024, Digest of Education Statistics 2023, Table 330.30. Average undergraduate tuition, fees, room, and board charges for full-time students in degree-granting postsecondary institutions, by percentile of charges and control and level of institution: Selected academic years, 2000-01 through 2022-23
- 2024, Digest of Education Statistics 2023, Table 330.40. Avg total cost of attendance for first-time, full-time undergraduate students in degree-granting postsec institutions, by ctrl & lvl of institution, living arrangement, & component of student costs: Selected academic yrs, 2010–11 through 2022–23
- 2023, Digest of Education Statistics 2022, Table 330.50. Average and percentiles of graduate tuition and required fees in degree-granting postsecondary institutions, by control of institution: Academic year 1989–90 through 2021–22
- 2023, The Condition of Education 2023: Loans for Undergraduate Students and Debt for Bachelor's Degree Recipients
- 2023, The Condition of Education 2023: Postsecondary Institution Revenues

Other Resources: **(Listed by Release Date)**

- 2024, Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS): IPEDS is a system of surveys designed to collect data from all primary providers of postsecondary education.
- 2024, IPEDS College Navigator
- 2024, National Postsecondary Student Aid Study (NPSAS) examines the characteristics of students in postsecondary education, with special focus on how they finance their education.
- 2023, 2019–20 National Postsecondary Student Aid Study (NPSAS:20): First Look at Student Financial Aid Estimates for 2019–20
- 2022, 2017–18 National Postsecondary Student Aid Study, Administrative Collection (NPSAS:18-AC): First Look at Student Financial Aid Estimates for 2017–18
- 2022, College Affordability Views and College Enrollment
- 2021, Postsecondary Institutions and Cost of Attendance in 2020-21; Degrees and Other Awards Conferred: 2019-20, and 12-Month Enrollment: 2019-20
- 2019, Student Financing of Undergraduate Education in 2015–16: Income, Tuition, and Total Price
- 2018, What High Schoolers and Their Parents Know About Public 4-Year Tuition and Fees in Their State

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